

FREE PORT GUIDE · PORT OF CALL

Cozumel, Mexico
Your Margaritaville at Sea day ashore

Turquoise water, world-famous reefs, laid-back beach clubs and real-deal tacos. Here's how to make every minute of your Cozumel day count and be back on board with time to spare.

SHIPS THAT CALL HERE
Islander from Tampa, and Beachcomber starting with its 2027 sailings

DOWNTOWN
San Miguel de Cozumel, about 10 minutes by taxi from the pier

ISLAND TIME
Eastern Standard Time all year (no daylight saving). Always go by ship time

WHERE ISLANDER DOCKS
SSA International Pier, south of town (check your daily Cruise News: piers can change)

MONEY
Mexican peso; U.S. dollars are taken almost everywhere tourists go

LANGUAGE
Spanish; English is widely spoken around the port and beach clubs

🛳️ Stepping off the ship

At the pier

- You'll walk down the pier into a **shopping plaza** full of stores and bars. It's fun to browse on your way back, so don't stop for long on the way out.
- **Booked a tour?** Head straight for the meeting spot on your voucher. Tour reps wait with signs just past the plaza.
- Bring your **ship card (your room key) and a photo ID**. You'll need both to get back on board.

Getting around

- **Taxis** wait at the official stand outside the pier gates. Fares are **set by zone and posted on a board**, priced per cab (up to 4 people), not per person. Snap a photo of the board and agree on the price before you get in.
- Pay in cash; small U.S. bills work best. Tipping your driver is appreciated but not expected.
- Walking to town takes about 30 minutes along a hot, busy road, so a taxi is well worth it.

⏰ **The golden rule:** plan to be back at the pier **at least an hour before all-aboard**. Lines at the gate and security can be long when several ships are in port, and the ship will not wait.

🌴 Pick your perfect Cozumel day

🏖️ Beach club and chill

5–15 min from the pier

The west coast south of the pier is lined with beach clubs: loungers, a pool, food and drinks, and calm, clear water. Many charge an entry fee or a food-and-drink minimum. Ask what's included before you settle in, and look for one with a snorkel area right off the beach.

🐠 Snorkel or dive the reefs

Half day

Cozumel sits on the Mesoamerican Reef, the second-largest reef system on Earth. A boat snorkel trip to the outer reefs is the classic choice. The water is famously clear, and the gentle current carries you along as you float.

🐢 Chankanaab Park

About 5 min from the pier

A national park with a beach, snorkeling in a sheltered cove, a lagoon, botanical gardens and sea life shows. It's an easy, well-organized day for families and first-timers. There's an entry fee, so bring your own snorkel gear to save on rentals.

🏛️ Mayan ruins at San Gervasio

About 25–30 min inland

The island's largest Maya site, once a pilgrimage stop honoring Ixchel, the goddess of fertility and the moon. It's shady and peaceful, and an hour or two covers it. Go early, before the heat, and bring bug spray.

🌊 The wild east side

Half day by jeep or tour

Rugged coastline, crashing surf and almost no crowds, plus Punta Sur Park at the south tip with its lighthouse and lagoon. It's beautiful for photos and a cold drink, but the open-ocean side is **not safe for swimming** in most spots.

🛍️ Downtown San Miguel

About 10 min by taxi

Stroll the waterfront and the main plaza, shop for silver, vanilla and tequila, and grab lunch a few blocks back from the water, where the prices are lower and the food is more local. It's a great no-plan day.

🌮 Local flavors to try

- **Fish tacos and ceviche:** fresh, simple and everywhere.
- **Cochinita pibil:** slow-roasted Yucatán pork with pickled red onions.
- **Fresh guacamole** with chips still warm from the fryer.
- **A real margarita,** of course. 🍹 Ask for fresh lime.
- **Mexican vanilla** to take home, sold in shops all over town.
- **Bottled water only.** Skip ice from street carts, but restaurant ice is generally fine.

💵 Money, shopping and tipping

- **Bring small U.S. bills** ($1s, $5s and $10s). Change often comes back in pesos.
- Credit cards work at most shops and restaurants. Taxis and street vendors want cash.
- If you need an ATM, use one inside a bank and decline the "conversion" offer.
- **Haggling is expected** at market stalls, but not in stores with price tags.
- Tip **10–15%** at restaurants if service isn't already added to the bill.
- Tip tour guides and boat crews a few dollars per person for a good day.

☀️ Weather and staying safe

Cozumel is warm all year, with daytime highs in the 80s to around 90°F. December to April is drier and breezier. June to October brings afternoon showers, and hurricane season runs June through November.

👉 **Check the forecast before you go: Cozumel 10-day forecast on weather.com** (or scan the code).

Protect the reef (and yourself)

- The parks and reef tours ask for **biodegradable, reef-safe sunscreen**. Pack it from home, because it's pricey on the island.
- **Don't touch or stand on coral.** It's alive, it's protected, and it scrapes.
- Wear a rash guard or T-shirt when snorkeling; the sun is strong on your back.

Smart cruiser habits

- Use the **official taxi stand** and book tours through the ship or a trusted company.
- Drink plenty of water. Heat sneaks up on you here.
- Scooter rentals look fun, but accidents are common. A jeep or taxi is the safer choice.
- Leave valuables on board, and carry a copy of your passport.

🎒 Your Cozumel day bag

- [ ] Ship card (room key) and photo ID
- [ ] Small U.S. bills for taxis and tips
- [ ] Reef-safe sunscreen, hat and sunglasses
- [ ] Swimsuit, cover-up and water shoes
- [ ] Your own snorkel mask (optional)
- [ ] Refillable water bottle
- [ ] Phone set to **ship time**, with an alarm
- [ ] Ship's port agent number from your Cruise News
- [ ] Waterproof phone pouch
- [ ] A copy of your passport (leave the original on board)

Want the best of Cozumel without the guesswork?

Our travel advisors can line up snorkel trips, beach clubs, ruins and island tours that fit your ship's time in port.

📲 **Scan the code** to browse and book Cozumel shore excursions.

Questions? **admin@thechillcompass.com**

Information current as of October 2026, gathered from Cozumel port schedules, park operators and cruise travel sources. Piers, times, prices and fees change, so please confirm with your ship's daily Cruise News and the posted rates on the day. Travel times are approximate. Excursions are booked through Shore Excursions Group, and we may earn a commission at no extra cost to you. The Chill Compass is an independent blog and is not affiliated with, endorsed by or sponsored by Margaritaville at Sea or Margaritaville Enterprises. All trademarks belong to their respective owners. Presented by Cruises Tours and Travel, LLC · Florida Seller of Travel Reg. No. ST150140.